STAFF SESSION

Practical ways to use AI tools

Play until you find the rough edges. Keep the judgment that lives closest to the patron.

Jose Ruiz-Vazquez · Austin Public Library

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What you leave with

A method

Sort any recurring task in five minutes.

A vocabulary

Delegated, calibrated, retained.

Permission to play

Find the rough edges yourself. Nobody can hand you the map.

"Keep this task human" is a valid answer to everything today.

What never goes in the box

A patron's name and hold list

NEVER.

The public flyer text

FINE.

Survey comments, one with a child's name

NEVER, until you strip the name yourself.

ALA, June 2026: patron names, contact information, and other private details are never entered into AI systems.

TYPE THIS. EXACTLY. THEN STOP.

"Write a 60-word blurb for a new monthly teen program at Round Rock Public Library."

Don't add context. Don't re-prompt. Read what comes back and leave it alone.

Same words in. Different words out.

Hands up

Who got a program name? Different from your neighbor's?

Hands up

An age range? A day of the week?

Hands up

A room in this building we don't have?

Nobody did anything wrong. Your job just changed from typing to choosing.

Three words

Delegated	The tool does it. I glance.
Calibrated	The tool drafts. I check every line.
Retained	I do it. The tool stays out.

One workflow: adult programming

Needs assessment	Synthesize survey text. I read the outliers.	Calibrated
Capacity	Draft partner outreach.	Delegated
Design	Draft the work plan.	Calibrated
Outreach	Flyer copy, three reading levels.	Delegated
Evaluate	Code feedback forms. I read the surprises.	Calibrated
Readiness	Ready for a learner?	Retained

THE ROUGH EDGE I FOUND

Every tool, at every price, writes a good draft. None of them can tell whether it's ready to put in front of a learner.

That judgment is where most of my time goes. It stays with the person who knows the room.

The readiness test

1. **Reading level.** Would the least confident person follow it?
2. **Assumed knowledge.** Is it true here?
3. **The missing step.** Where does a first-timer get stuck?
4. **The local fact.** What's wrong about our building or rules?
5. **Tone.** Talked down to, or talked past?
6. **The one thing.** Is the most important idea the biggest?

Frontline prototypes. Tech hardens.

Shelf-reading assignments

Tool splits ranges and schedules. I decide who's ready for which section.

Desk stat tracker

Tool tallies and charts. I decide what counts.

Weekly report

Tool drafts from my notes. I write the judgment paragraph.

Each one started as a complaint at the desk.

Sort the desk

My recurring workflow: _____

Stage · D / C / R · why

1. _____ ___ _____
2. _____ ___ _____
3. _____ ___ _____
4. _____ ___ _____
5. _____ ___ _____

The most repetitive thing you do. Not the most interesting.

List its stages. Tag each one. One word for why.

Five minutes. In silence.

Three shares

Delegated

One stage you'd hand over, and why.

Calibrated

One stage you'd check line by line, and why.

Retained

One stage you're keeping, and why.

The retained column isn't what AI can't do. It's what you decided to keep.

WHY YOU HAVE TO FIND THE EDGES YOURSELF

40%+

higher quality on tasks inside the tool's range

19 pts

more likely to be wrong on a task just outside it

The tasks looked alike.

Dell'Acqua, McFowland, Mollick et al., Harvard Business School working paper, 2023. 758 consultants.

Ten hours

Most people quit before ten hours. Push through and you'll have a map. Three places to spend them:

Anthropic AI Fluency

Free, an afternoon. Delegation, Description, Discernment, Diligence.

ALA Guidance on AI in Libraries

Adopted June 2026. Privacy, staff authority, literacy.

PLA AI resources

Policy, staff training, patron training.

Where did your judgment stay load-bearing?

Questions.

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